ONPOINT SOLUTIONS LLC

Does the structure of a CoC change how well it works?

A short summary of the report "CoC Governance: What the Research and the Data Show."

The main finding

We did not find one CoC structure that works better than the others. The data did not show a better result for any structure that we could measure. The research on nonprofit boards says the same. How a board works is more important than how it is set up.

What we found

- **Boards.** No one board model is best. Good boards have clear roles. They work well as a team. They plan for the future. They check their own work. Most problems come from boards that do too little, not from boards that do too much.
- **Money.** A CoC that got more money did not always do better. Most of the growth in money came from growth of the national program.
- **Lead agency.** A lead agency can be a government office or a nonprofit group. Neither type did better on all measures.
- **Special HUD status.** 18 CoCs have the HUD status Unified Funding Agency (UFA). They did not do better than the other 357 CoCs.
- **Data coverage.** Performance numbers come from the Homeless Management Information System (HMIS). A CoC that puts more of its services in HMIS finds more people who return to homelessness. That CoC can look worse, but its data are more complete.
- **Housing costs.** In large cities, people stay homeless for more days where rents are high and low-cost homes are few. Housing costs did not predict how many people moved into housing. They also did not predict how many people became homeless again.
- **Three CoCs that improved.** Detroit, Cleveland/Cuyahoga County and the Georgia Balance of State got better in a steady way over 6 years. Each board has a different design. Their funding did not rise with their results in a steady way.

What this means for a CoC board

- Do not change the structure of a CoC only to get better results. The data do not show that this will help.
- Look at how the board works. Does it make decisions? Does it give work to others and check that work? Does it use good data?
- Check the data coverage in HMIS. It changes what the numbers show.
- Look at local housing costs when you compare one CoC to another.

What we cannot say

- The data show links between things. They do not show that one thing causes another.
- Some groups in the study are small. For example, 18 CoCs have UFA status. Some results can come from chance.
- Public data do not show how a CoC board works in daily practice.